

rates mixing GSM/CDMA/WLL offerings required a degree in advanced math for understanding, along with the proliferation of tariff plans, a consumer was left bewildered.

Baijal did not wave a wand and make it all better. Nothing so romantic; he was a newcomer to this telecom regulation business, fresh from the Indian bureaucracy. He was, thankfully, not averse to looking for help, and thus he engaged outside consultants, often from foreign countries, to gain insights into global best practices—something none of his predecessors cared to do. Little by little, he fixed things.

First to be weeded were the tariff plans. TRAI put a cap on the number of plans that can be offered at any point of time by the access providers (25 was the magic number). Baijal opined that the reduction in tariffs would increase penetration, pointing out that there were 10 million mobile connections in 2002 a number that leaped to 30 million in 2003 as tariffs dropped.

Under Baijal, TRAI wants to connect every Indian together. Convergence of services is where TRAI is heading. As a milestone to that road, the idea of a unified license was given birth. This would allow conversion of all telecom licenses into unified licenses enabling any operator to offer any type of service.

With such a device in place, there would be only two types of services, fixed and mobile. Any mobile service; whether WLL or cellular would simply be recognised as “mobile service.” But this suggestion was not limited to phones: “Unified license implies that a customer can get all types of telecom services, from a unified license operator, technology permitting. These services would include telephony, Internet, broadband, cable TV, DTH, TV & radio broadcasting.” Baijal spoke of the recommendations: “...you’ll realise that we have created an enabling regulation. We have also taken into account future aspects like convergence. If things work out, a cable TV provider may be able to provide telecom services too (vice versa too would hold good) under the unified licensing regime.” What TRAI has proposed under Baijal is a proliferation of choice, and choice, as we all know can only be good for the consumer.

We salute Baijal and his associates at TRAI for ensuring that the power to choose remains with the consumer.

TREND > Falling Hardware And Software Prices

Technology For Cheap

Cheap is in. In 2004, affordable laptops triggered a domino effect of cheap hardware across the PC spectrum. Afraid to lose market share to laptops, OEMs slashed prices of desktop computers. Today, you can buy a good desktop PC for less than Rs 20,000.

Software has also followed the trend. The Open Source movement has brought great software at the best price—free, to our desktops. OpenOffice.org for a great office suite, Firefox for a great Web browser, Thunderbird for a great e-mail client, and countless other small and eminently usable programs await your use.



The effects of this trend have been telling. Sun recently announced that Solaris 10, its latest cross-platform OS which cost them over US \$500 million to develop will be distributed free. Sun is also committed to release the source code for Solaris 10 to the community. Microsoft has also been forced to be more sensitive to price. While Windows XP Starter Edition may be emasculated, it is a positive step towards lowering the price of Microsoft’s platform.

Cheap is indeed in.

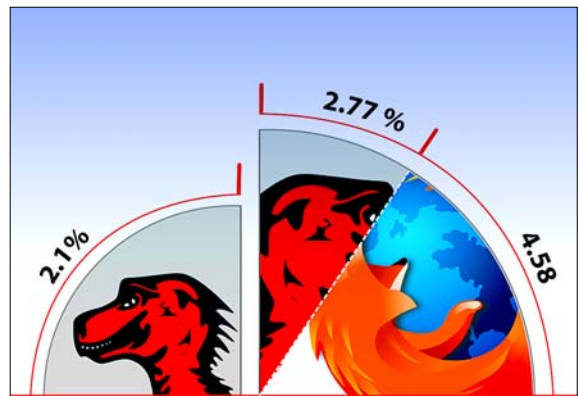
TECHNOLOGY > WEB STANDARDS

Return Of The Standards

During the Browser Wars between Netscape and Microsoft, Web “standards” took a beating and the W3C was often rolled over.

Today, something strange is afoot in the Internet space. Bit by bit, the Web is reclaiming the standards and this time, no single company is influential enough to spoil the party.

It all boils down to the fact that there isn’t a single, widely used service on the Web. Take Web



According to OneStat.com, standards compliant Mozilla has seen its share shoot to 7.35 per cent from 2.1 per cent in May 2004. Out of which 4.58 per cent belongs to Firefox

mail as an example: Hotmail, Yahoo! GMail, Outgun, Hotpop, Lycos, Netscape, Rediffmail, Indiatimes... you have choice. When there isn’t a dominant player to dictate its agenda, standards survive and thrive.

Today, creators are dictating the field. Why should a programmer, for instance, code for two different Web browsers just so his Web site is usable by the majority? Standards such as HTML, XHTML, CSS, Javascript, XML and PNG are thus enjoying wide-scale adoption by Web programmers and designers. Up and coming browsers: Firefox and Opera for the Windows platform, Safari for the Mac world are swearing by W3C compliance for the sake of the creators and their audience. These tools are in turn used by the creators for the compliance offered and the circle completes.

Even Microsoft, whose Web browser is arguably the least compliant, is embracing the idea. Its adoption of XML within the MS Office suite is a prelude to things to come; its C++ compiler is the most compliant of the lot. Rising Firefox installs (reportedly, Firefox 1.0 was downloaded more than 1 million times on the day of